Mauryas, a far richer material culture made its appearance, marked by the use of burnt bricks, North Black Polished Ware, polished stone pestles, shell bangles, beads of terracotta and semi-precious stones (jasper, carnelian, crystal, coral, lapis lazuli), coins and a disc stone bearing a typically Mauryan relief of standing goddesses flanked by palm trees and various animals.[23] A major moment in the life of any site is when a system of fortifications is constructed, indicating what is considered worthy of defence and consolidation, and at Sannathi the first phase of the fortifications—constructed by cutting a moat and heaping the earth to create walls—goes back to Mauryan times.

The Maurya advent seems to have coincided with prosperity of a kind not seen before, but that would not in itself suggest that this important town was established by Ashoka, or that he established it after conquering the region. The date of the urban centre cannot be precisely established, but that it existed in the time of Ashoka seems fairly certain—the presence of his edicts suggests this. Equally, the stupa of Kanaganahalli, situated very close to Sannathi, was first established in Mauryan times. This was in the form of an earthen mound, some 16 metres in diameter and rising to a height of a little over 7 metres. The Mauryan antiquities included a mutilated polished sandstone lion capital fragment on the west of the stupa, along with a single sherd of North Black Polished Ware. Ashoka, we have seen, established stupas marked by his various messages at many locations, and the first stupa here must have been built with his patronage.

On the question of Ashoka's conquest of Sannathi, the evidence is more tenuous. A great deal has been invested in the etymology of the name of the large 80-hectare habitational mound here, where the cultural levels just described were recovered. The mound bears the name of Ranamandala, suggesting it was a battlefield. K.P. Poonacha, who led the excavations of the Archaeological Survey of India, believes 'the place may be the historic battlefield or site wherein the Mauryas subjugated the local Satavahanas in